



This depiction of the Battle of Yashima during the Gempei Wars illustrates a heavily armed Minamoto discovering the terrified mother of Emperor Taira.

EMPEROR FREDERICK BARBAROSSA'S FIFTH EXPEDITION TO ITALY in 1176 (see also 1151–55) ended in disaster for the imperial forces when his army was crushed at the **Battle of Legnano**. The battle marked one of the earliest occasions in the medieval era when cavalry were defeated by infantry. This had class implications as knights on horseback generally belonged to the feudal aristocracy, while footmen with pikes represented freemen of the rising bourgeoisie. In 1177, Frederick was forced to concede the **Peace of Venice** with the pope; a prelude to the more

comprehensive Peace of Constance in 1183 (see 1181–85).

Now reconciled with the emperor, **Pope Alexander III** was able to call an ecumenical council at the Lateran Palace in Rome, in 1179. The council decreed that **papal elections** would be solely in the hands of the cardinals, and that a two-thirds majority was needed to elect a pope. It was hoped that this would draw a line under years of contention between papal candidates elected by the antiimperial party and “**anti-popes**”—persons selected by the emperor to oppose the legitimately elected or sitting pope.

In 1176, the army of **Byzantine emperor** Manuel Comnenus was destroyed by the Turks of the **Sultanate of Rum** (see 1100–05) at the **Battle of Myriocephalum**. The Byzantines were never again able to send land forces to help the Crusaders.

The **Gempei Wars** (1180–85) in Japan

Pope Alexander III
This 14th-century fresco shows Pope Alexander III presenting a sword to the Venetian Doge for use against the emperor, Frederick Barbarossa.



COAL AND IRON IN MEDIEVAL EUROPE

Growing populations, new agricultural implements, and constant military activity increased the demand for iron in the Middle Ages. Charcoal was still the main source of power for iron forges, but deforestation caused wood shortages. As a consequence, demand for coal increased and scavenging for sea coal was increasingly supplemented by mining. The first record of a coal mine comes from Escomb near Durham, in northern England in 1183.

marked the **end of Taira domination** of Japan (see 641–650), and the start of the **Minamoto shogunate**. Civil wars in 1156 and 1159 had left control of Japan in the hands of Taira no Kiyomori (c.1118–81), who quickly assumed a similar level of power to the **Fujiwara clan** (see 851–860). Not only did he act as prime minister, but he also married his daughters to the imperial family, enabling him to place his infant grandson on the throne as emperor in 1180. But his excessive lust for power and perceived corruption alienated his provincial supporters, and in the same year there was an uprising by the **Minamoto clan** against Taira rule, which grew into the five-year-long Gempei Wars.

“**SALADIN'S HOPE HAD AN EASY PASSAGE, HIS PATHS WERE FRAGRANT, HIS GIFTS POURED OUT, ... HIS POWER WAS MANIFEST, HIS AUTHORITY SUPREME.**”

Imad al Din, Secretary to Saladin, from *Lightning of Syria*, c.1200

BY THE 1180s, THE CRUSADER KINGDOMS OF OUTREMER (“beyond the sea,” as they were known in Europe) were in an increasingly precarious position. Europe was deaf to entreaties for **Crusader reinforcements**, and the Christian Byzantines were preoccupied with other matters, such as war with Norman Sicily. Meanwhile, their Muslim opponents were gathering under the leadership of **Saladin**, or Salah al-Din, (c. 1137–93) the sultan of Egypt and Syria. By 1183, he had suppressed Christian rebels at Edessa and Aleppo, and with both sides reeling from the effects of a drought, had brokered a peace treaty with the leper **king of Jerusalem, Baldwin IV** (c. 1161–85). The uneasy peace was shattered, however, by the actions of Reynald of Châtillon, an adventurer from the Second Crusade, who persistently raided unarmed caravans of Islamic pilgrims, and sponsored a pirate fleet that pillaged the Red Sea.

Saladin mobilized his army, intent on punishing Reynald, but his progress was checked by **Frankish fortresses** and another prolonged **famine**. In 1185, Baldwin died and his sickly infant nephew inherited the crown as **Baldwin V** (1177–86).

In 1183, the peace between Emperor Frederick Barbarossa and his Italian foes was ratified as the Peace of Constance, but although imperial authority over Italy was recognized, the **Lombard** cities were granted effective autonomy.

The **Battle of Dannonura** of 1185 marked the climax of the **Gempei Wars**. Warrior Minamoto Yoshitsune, younger brother of Yoritomo, the founder of the shogunate, destroyed the Taira in the naval battle.

Saladin, sultan of Egypt and Syria
Saladin escapes from battle on a camel in this 18th-century engraving. He was renowned as a generous and principled leader.



1176 Byzantine army defeated by Turks at **Battle of Myriocephalum**

1176 **Battle of Legnano** between Frederick Barbarossa and the Lombard League

1177 Kingdom of Champa sacks Khmer city of Angkor

1177 **Peace of Venice** between Frederick Barbarossa and the pope

1179 Third Lateran Council held in Rome

1180 Philip II Augustus (r. 1180–1223) becomes king of France

1180 **Gempei Wars** in Japan (to 1185)

1181 Accession of Jayavarman VII of Khmer (reigned until 1215)

1183 **Peace of Constance** between Frederick Barbarossa and Lombard League

1184 Diet of Mainz; leads to Third Crusade

1185 The Taira defeated at **Battle of Dannonura** in Japan

1185 Second Bulgarian Empire is founded (to 1396)